



Summary of Pre-Suasion

Original book by Robert Cialdini

Experts in the art of persuasion, whether orators, salespersons, or politicians, often focus on fine-tuning their *arguments*. But, according to psychologist Robert Cialdini, this approach fails to consider another key component of persuasion—what happens before we begin conveying our argument. In his 2016 book, *Pre-Suasion*, Cialdini argues that to make our audience receptive to our message, **we must optimize the moments *before* persuasion.**

In this guide, we'll discuss Cialdini's insight that people are susceptible to influence the moment before they make a decision, and we'll examine how words, images, and environments can influence people in that moment. Next, we'll discuss ways to "pre-suade" your audience by aligning with people's preferences for consistency, likable communicators, authority figures, and people who share their identity. Finally, we'll consider how to anchor the behavioral changes that result from pre-suasion by getting your audience to make a commitment. Throughout the guide, we'll discuss pushback against Cialdini's arguments and explore supplemental advice from other authors on how to influence people.

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1-Page Summary

Experts in the art of persuasion, whether orators, salespeople, or politicians, often focus on fine-tuning their *arguments*. But, according to psychologist Robert Cialdini, this approach fails to consider another key component of persuasion—what happens before we begin conveying our argument. In his 2016 book, *Pre-Suasion*, Cialdini argues that to make our audience receptive to our message, **we must optimize the moments *before* persuasion.**

As the author of the bestseller *Influence* (2006), Cialdini is one of the foremost authorities on the psychological secrets underlying successful persuasion. He's currently the Regents' Professor Emeritus of Psychology and Marketing at Arizona State University, and he formerly worked as a behavioral scientist for Barack Obama's 2012 presidential campaign. In *Pre-Suasion*, Cialdini builds upon *Influence*'s foundational principles by explaining how we can effectively steer our audience's attention before we even begin our argument.

In this guide, we'll begin by discussing Cialdini's insight that people are particularly susceptible to influence the moment before they make a decision. Next, we'll examine the three instruments he introduces for influencing people in that critical moment—words, images, and environments. Afterward, we'll discuss some of the things you can use to direct your audience's attention toward, including their preference for consistency, likable communicators, authoritative figures, and members of their in-group. Finally, we'll consider how to anchor the behavioral changes that result from pre-suasion by getting your audience to make a commitment. We'll also discuss pushback against Cialdini's arguments and consider supplemental advice from other authors on how to influence people.

Priming: A Controversial Foundation for Cialdini's Arguments

Pre-Suasion relies heavily on the notion of *priming*, made popular by Daniel Kahneman's 2011 book *Thinking, Fast and Slow*. As Kahneman relates, priming is when the **words and environments we're exposed to subconsciously impact our behavior**. For example, Kahneman discusses one study in which half of the participants were exposed to words related to the elderly—such as “Florida,” “bald,” or “forgetful”—while other participants were exposed to a random set of words. After this exposure, those “primed” with words about the elderly walked significantly slower than those exposed to random words; according to the researchers, this was evidence of priming.

In *Pre-Suasion*, Cialdini introduces priming as a useful tool to pre-suade an audience. However, **scientists have been unable to replicate any of the studies** that allegedly show the impact of priming, and Kahneman admitted afterward that he **leaned too heavily on faulty studies**. For this reason, Cialdini's conclusions drawn from the many studies about priming throughout *Pre-Suasion* should be taken with caution.

The Foundation of Pre-Suasion

Before delving into Cialdini's specific strategies for effective pre-suasion, we'll start by discussing the critical moment in the pre-suasive process—the moment immediately before your audience makes a decision. We'll also outline the two primary reasons why such moments are critical to the decision-making process: First, because people intuitively believe these moments to be very important; and second, because people

think the information they encounter just before making a decision is causally relevant to their decisions.

(Shortform note: Because *Pre-Suasion* became a bestseller and Cialdini has given many talks about it, the concept of “pre-suasion” has become increasingly mainstream. For example, new studies have [tested the efficacy of pre-suasive techniques](#) in mail marketing, finding them slightly less effective than techniques related to social exchange. Researchers have also applied the notion of pre-suasion to specific industries such as [motorcycle sales](#).)

The Importance of the Moment Before Deciding

According to Cialdini, the key to pre-suasion lies in the insight that **the most salient factors immediately before people make a decision have a disproportionate impact on that decision**. He cites several scientific studies suggesting that people respond differently to requests for assistance depending on the prompt they answer immediately beforehand.

For example, he points to one study where subjects were randomly split into two groups: One was asked if they were *unhappy* with their social lives, while the other was asked if they were *happy* with their social lives. Participants who were asked whether they were unhappy were 375% more likely to respond that they were —illustrating that simply using the word “happy” makes people more aware of the positive aspects of their social relationships, while using the word “unhappy” makes them more aware of the negative aspects.

(Shortform note: In the realm of professional polling, experts acknowledge that [how a question is phrased can massively influence the results](#), just like the above study suggests. For this reason, pollsters spend substantial amounts of time working on *questionnaire development*, the practice of designing questionnaires and polls that don’t bias respondents’ answers. This includes deciding whether to ask open-ended or closed-ended questions, since respondents will often offer different responses to these two types of questions.)

Why Are These Moments Pivotal?

Cialdini admits that these studies don’t show *why* the moments right before a decision have an outsize influence. To fill that gap, he argues that the objects of attention influence decisions for two reasons: **People naturally believe that the objects of their attention are important and causally relevant to their decisions**.

Reason #1: The Objects of Attention Are Important

First, Cialdini points to several studies illustrating that **people find the current objects of their attention more important than those outside of their attention**. For example, he describes how people’s perceptions of the importance of 9/11 changed with the amount of media coverage. In 2011, a research team asked people to name especially impactful historical events in the last 70 years. Two weeks before the tenth anniversary of 9/11, about 30% of respondents named 9/11 as one such event—but right around the anniversary, amid a flurry of media attention, a full 65% of respondents did. Two weeks later, that figure had dropped back to 30%. In other words, as the events of 9/11 became more present in respondents’ minds, they became more likely to deem them important.

(Shortform note: As economist Robert Shiller explains in *Irrational Exuberance*, the media’s influence over people’s views can also [impact the stock market by drawing attention to market swings](#). In other words, the media doesn’t passively report on news about the stock market; it actively *shapes* the market by causing investors to overestimate the importance of various factors. For example, if the media reported on an underwhelming earnings report from Apple, investors might assign this news too much importance, causing them to overreact and impulsively sell Apple stock.)

Reason #2: The Objects of Attention Play a Causal Role

Building on his claim that individuals unconsciously assign high importance to things they're paying attention to, Cialdini argues that **people also believe that the objects of attention are causally impactful**, meaning they're relevant to the decision-making process.

To illustrate, he points to experiments in which participants observed a scripted conversation of a couple deliberating about which movie to see, with some participants seeing only the man's face and others seeing only the woman's. These participants consistently believed that the person whose face they saw drove the choice—if participants saw the man's face, they believed he drove the choice to see the movie, whereas those who saw the woman's face believed she drove that choice.

(Shortform note: In *Thinking, Fast and Slow*, Kahneman argues that our tendency to make causal judgments based on superficial information (like whose face we're observing) is a byproduct of *System 1 thinking*—our mind's *automatic mode of thinking* that operates without conscious effort. System 1 thinking *quickly creates coherent narratives about the world*, making us liable to mistakenly assume causation between two events that are merely correlated.)

The Instruments of Pre-Suasion

Having established the foundation of pre-suasion—the fact that people are especially susceptible to influence the moment before they make a decision—we'll now turn to the specific *instruments* of influence that make pre-suasion possible. According to Cialdini, there are three such instruments: language, images, and environments.

Instrument #1: Language

Cialdini says that **precise word choice is an essential tool for successful pre-suasion**, citing various studies that reveal how words can shape behavior and underlying opinions.

For example, in one experiment, researchers exposed one group of participants to sets of scrambled words that formed violent sentences when unscrambled (for example, “him shot she” became “she shot him”). Another group saw scrambled words that formed nonviolent sentences (for example, “him saw she” became “she saw him.”) Then, researchers had the subjects partake in an experiment that involved electrically shocking another subject and choosing the intensity of the shocks. Cialdini notes that the results were shocking: Those exposed to violent language beforehand chose shock levels 48% higher than those exposed to nonviolent language, suggesting the words influenced their behavior.

(Shortform note: According to some psychologists, words aren't the only means of increasing violence levels. For example, one American Psychological Association task force found that violent video games have been linked to *increased aggressive behavior and decreased empathy*

In another study, researchers examined the impact on people who read reports likening crime to a “beast” versus those who read reports likening crime to a “virus.” Cialdini writes that by changing a single word in the report, researchers found that readers came to drastically different conclusions about crime: Those who read the report comparing crime to a beast were more likely to prefer punitive solutions that involved catching and imprisoning criminals, whereas those who read the report comparing crime to a virus became more likely to prefer a systemic approach focused on remedying the underlying causes of crime.

(Shortform note: This study suggests that the words we use have outsize effects on our beliefs and behavior—an idea that's central to *the inclusive language movement*. Proponents of this movement recommend

using inclusive terms to mitigate subtle forms of discrimination. This includes *people-first* language, which emphasizes people's personhood over other characteristics—this might involve saying “a person with autism” rather than “an autistic person.” Saying “a person with autism” implies that their autism is *one of many aspects of their personhood*, whereas saying “an autistic person” wrongly implies that their autism is their whole identity.)

Instrument #2: Images

Cialdini clarifies that words aren't the only effective vehicle for pre-suasion: **Carefully tailored images can also unconsciously influence people's behavior.** Images, he says, can even propel people toward success when used correctly.

To illustrate, Cialdini cites a study by researchers who sought to improve productivity at a fundraising call center. In this study, workers were given a piece of paper outlining the key facts about the university for which they were fundraising. Half of these fact sheets were printed on blank sheets of paper, while the other half were printed on paper with a photograph of a victorious runner finishing a race. On average, the employees whose fact sheets included the image of the runner raised 60% more money than their counterparts. Thus, Cialdini suggests that the image partially induced higher achievement among these workers.

(Shortform note: Although this study found a statistically significant difference in workers' achievements based on whether their sheets included an image of a victorious runner, that doesn't necessarily mean the picture of the runner was *responsible* for the difference. As Carl T. Bergstrom and Jevin D. West point out in *Calling Bullshit*, many published studies reveal statistically significant results solely because of *publication bias*—the fact that *scientific journals typically publish studies with statistically significant results* instead of those in which the results show no significant results between groups. For this reason, any studies that *haven't* found similar effects may simply not appear in published research journals.)

Instrument #3: Environments

Cialdini contends that **specific cues in the environment can affect performance**, both in school and at work. In turn, Cialdini implies that to pre-suasively induce a change in our audience's behavior, we should carefully tailor our audience's environment.

Regarding classroom performance, Cialdini points to research examining how to increase female students' scores on standardized math tests. Researchers have found that several small changes to the testing environment consistently increase female students' scores: including only female students in the testing room, using female proctors, and not asking students to write their gender at the beginning of the test. According to Cialdini, these changes make female students less cognizant of the stereotype that women are worse at math, in turn boosting their performance.

(Shortform note: Another way to enable women to succeed in math—not just on tests, but in college and beyond—is to *introduce them to female role models who have thrived at math*. Meeting such role models undermines stereotypical beliefs and causes more female students to believe they can succeed at math in the first place.)

Regarding work performance, Cialdini discusses the anecdotal experience of a manager at a consulting firm who realized that consultants' performance creating employee incentive plans increased significantly when they worked in central offices with glass windows. According to Cialdini, this was because the consultants created better incentive plans when they were surrounded by (and thus constantly aware of) the employees for whom they were creating the plans.

(Shortform note: Although working out of a central office with glass windows isn't an option for everyone, experts note that there's a [wide array of strategies](#) that anyone can use to create a more effective work environment that "pre-suades" you and your colleagues to perform well. For example, a workplace with significant natural light can increase your energy levels and productivity, while reducing clutter at your desk can minimize distractions and therefore make you more efficient.)

Pre-Suade by Aligning With People's Preferences

Although we've discussed Cialdini's instruments for steering people's attention in the moment before deciding, we haven't yet discussed how to *use* these instruments. In this section, we'll consider ways you can direct your audience's attention by aligning with their preferences—three of which (desire for consistency, deference toward authority, and desire for likability) are originally from Cialdini's previous book, [Influence](#), and one of which (the importance of unity) is new to *Pre-Suasion*.

(Shortform note: In addition to consistency, authority, and likability, Cialdini highlights three further principles in both *Pre-Suasion* and [Influence](#): reciprocity, social proof, and scarcity. Reciprocity refers to the notion that [we often feel obligated to repay those who have helped us](#). Social proof refers to the idea that we're more likely to agree with something if [it seems like everyone else agrees with it](#). Finally, scarcity refers to the fact that we're more attracted to items that [seem to have limited availability](#). Cialdini contends that by leveraging these additional principles, we can more effectively pre-suade and persuade our audience to act as we desire.)

Preference #1: Consistency

Cialdini first explains that **people are naturally inclined to think and act in a way that's consistent with their pre-existing beliefs and actions**. Accordingly, reminding people of this desire for consistency can be a powerful tool for successful pre-suasion.

(Shortform note: In academic works published elsewhere, Cialdini explains that [consistency exists on a spectrum](#), such that some individuals are more concerned with internal consistency than others. Thus, although he writes as if we *all* desire internal consistency in *Pre-Suasion*, it's more accurate to say that we all desire it to varying degrees.)

To demonstrate this desire for consistency, Cialdini points to a study examining how best to increase the participation rate of those who signed up for a blood drive. The researchers found that during a reminder call the day before the blood drive, eliciting verbal confirmation from participants made it significantly more likely that they would show up the next day—the participation rate increased from 70% to 82%.

For this reason, effective pre-suasion often involves making our desire for internal consistency more salient. For example, vegetarianism advocates from People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals (PETA) might appeal to the fact that most individuals think it would be wrong to consume their household pets, even though they regularly consume other animals. In so doing, PETA would try to convince people to become vegetarians by appealing to their desire for internal consistency.

(Shortform note: In [Influence](#), Cialdini goes into further detail about *why* we crave internal consistency. He writes that consistency allows us to [make quick judgments without assessing each situation individually](#), meaning that it frees us from the burden of deliberating about every single decision. For example, if you've signed up for the annual blood drive each of the past five years, the desire for consistency will cause you to automatically do so in the future, rather than deciding whether to participate every single year.)

Preference #2: Authority

Cialdini admits that shifting people's focus toward their internal desire for consistency isn't enough if you—the pre-suader—don't come across as authoritative. According to Cialdini, **people naturally defer to those whom they perceive as authoritative**, meaning that effective pre-suaders should attempt to underscore their own credibility.

(Shortform note: Although it's natural to defer to authority, this deference can become a fallacy—namely, the “appeal to authority” fallacy—when we argue that something *must be correct merely because an authority figure says so*. For this reason, it's best to take statements from authority figures as *strong evidence*, but not *conclusive proof*, that a statement is true.)

To illustrate the tendency to defer to authority, Cialdini discusses an experiment in which individuals were asked to answer complex questions about economics while undergoing a brain scan. He notes that when the participants were initially evaluating these questions, their brain activity surged in the area responsible for high-level problem-solving. However, when these participants heard proposed answers from professional economists, their brain activity crashed as they mindlessly deferred to the expert.

How Much Power Do Authority Figures Really Have Over Us?

The well-known “Milgram Shock experiment,” run by psychologist Stanley Milgram, further illustrates the extent to which individuals defer to authority. Rather than measuring how this deference shows up in the brain, he measured its impact on *behavior*.

Milgram told participants that they'd serve the role of a “teacher” whose job was to administer electric shocks to a “student” (who was actually an actor pretending to be shocked) whenever the student answered a question incorrectly. After each shock, the experimenter (who was the authority figure) told the participants to increase the voltage by 15 volts.

Milgram reports that *65% of participants ultimately increased the voltage all the way to the maximum level of 450 volts*—a level that would have posed serious threats to the learner's safety—just because the authority figure told them to do so.

Cialdini concludes that making our own authority salient can be a winning strategy for pre-suasion. To do so, he recommends that you **establish your credibility by admitting a shortcoming early in conversation**, since people perceive those who are candid about their weaknesses as more credible. For instance, if you're a politician on the campaign trail, confessing to previous mistakes—say, support for an unsuccessful bill in years past—could actually make you seem *more* authoritative in the eyes of your constituents.

(Shortform note: Psychologists have found that in addition to making you more *credible*, a display of weakness can also make you more *likable*. For example, in one study, participants watched a recording of an individual taking a verbal quiz and answering 92% of the questions correctly. However, half of the participants watched a version in which the individual spilled coffee on himself at the end of the quiz, while the other half watched a video without the spilled coffee. The study found that participants who watched him spill coffee on himself *rated him as considerably more likable afterwards*, compared to those who didn't watch him spill coffee on himself.)

Preference #3: Likability

While people place great weight on the views of authoritative experts, they're less likely to do so if the experts are unlikable. Conversely, Cialdini writes that **people are inclined to agree with those whom they find likable**, which suggests that drawing attention to your likable traits is an excellent pre-suasive strategy. He recommends two strategies for making yourself more likable: Highlight similarities with your audience and give your audience compliments.

(Shortform note: Much as Cialdini discusses likability in *Pre-Suasion*, Dale Carnegie discusses a set of likability principles in *How to Win Friends and Influence People*. However, his recommendations go beyond Cialdini's advice. For example, he offers straightforward tips like [saying the name of the person whom you're talking to](#) because it makes them feel important and [smiling frequently to show that you like them](#).)

Strategy #1: Highlight Similarities

Cialdini points out that **people are predisposed to like those who are similar to them**. He relates that there are many examples of this phenomenon: Babies, for instance, are more likely to smile at adults who mimic the babies' facial expressions.

(Shortform note: According to one study, 3-month-old babies not only prefer adults who mimic their own facial expressions, but they also [prefer to look at the faces of men who share their caregivers' ethnicity](#). The study exposed a group of 3-month-old white babies to pictures of white, Middle Eastern, African, and Asian men. Ultimately, the study found that the white babies spent a significantly longer amount of time staring at the pictures of white men than men of other ethnicities, suggesting a preference for white men's faces.)

In the context of pre-suasion, then, Cialdini implies that we should draw attention to features that we share with our audience. For example, imagine that you're a door-to-door salesman in Boston, where the majority of your potential customers are fans of the New England Patriots. To effectively pre-suade—and thereby increase your sales—you could choose to wear a Patriots hat that highlights your similarities with your audience.

(Shortform note: In situations where you *don't* have much in common with your audience, Carnegie's advice in *How to Win Friends and Influence People* may be useful. Carnegie recommends that you [focus on your audience's interests](#), even if you don't share them. For example, even if you don't know anything about Bitcoin, if you're talking to someone who's obsessed with it, it could be wise to ask questions to show them that you care about their interests.)

Strategy #2: Give Compliments

In addition to underscoring similarities with your audience, Cialdini also recommends that you **give genuine compliments to win people's affection**. To show as much, Cialdini points to a study in which students received fliers from a clothing store that praised them for being "fashionable and stylish." In response to the fliers, these students reported significantly more positive attitudes toward the store and a higher likelihood of shopping there.

Paying people compliments can make you seem more likable, thus making you more effective at pre-suasion. For example, imagine that you're a teacher seeking high performance scores from your students to bolster your case for receiving a raise. Just before distributing the questionnaires, you could remind your students that they've been a joy to have in class to steer them toward more favorable reviews.

(Shortform note: Although compliments can be an effective tool for winning people's affection, experts warn that [you have to be careful not to overdo it](#). After all, we often become *less* affectionate when we believe that someone's compliments are driven by ulterior motives, since that makes us doubt their sincerity. For example, if the fliers from the above study instead told students they were "the most fashionable person we

know,” the students might have found the messaging off-putting and been less likely to shop at the store.)

Preference #4: Connectedness

Although consistency, authority, and likability are all potent desires, Cialdini clarifies that one more desire is even more powerful: connectedness (which he calls “unity”). According to Cialdini, **individuals are especially susceptible to influence from people with whom they feel connected**. Further, he explains that this connection takes two forms: connection through identity and connection through activity.

Form #1: Connection Through Identity

Cialdini contends that **people feel deeply connected with fellow members of a shared identity group**, or “in-group,” such as their family, country, or religion. He relates that this unity has an evolutionary origin: Because humans are programmed by natural selection to pass down their genetic material, they automatically favor those who *share* this genetic material—that is, their families. In fact, Cialdini notes that neuroscientists have even found that people tend to project their own personality traits onto other in-group members, suggesting that they consider those who share their identities as extensions of themselves.

(Shortform note: According to experts, the evolutionary roots of our sense of shared identity with our family also gave rise to *tribalism*, an **unflinching loyalty toward our in-group** that causes hostility toward perceived members of the out-group. They contend that this tribalism is especially prominent in politics, where conservatives and progressives don’t merely *disagree* with one another, but often *disdain* one another to the point of hostility.)

Given the importance of shared identity, Cialdini suggests that we should direct our audience’s attention toward any mutual aspects of identity to pre-suade them. For example, an Italian politician giving a speech on the eve of election day could begin the speech with, “As your fellow Italian,” to underscore the identity that they share with voters. Alternatively, a corporate executive could use language likening the company to a family to foster a sense of unity among employees.

(Shortform note: One institution well-known for cultivating a shared identity is the US military, whose members often report a **deeply ingrained interconnectedness** with one another. This sense of interconnectedness is crucial in wartime, when the ability to function as a coherent unit is essential to creating effective units. Leaders interested in using Cialdini’s principle of connectedness for pre-suasion could begin by studying how the US military builds such a strong sense of shared identity.)

Form #2: Connection Through Activity

What if you want to pre-suade someone but you don’t share an identity with them? Cialdini suggests that **we can manufacture a sense of unity through collective action**, citing an array of studies to show as much.

For instance, in one study, researchers separated participants into two teams—one that walked in lockstep and one that walked out of sync—before having the teams play a game in which they chose between maximizing self-interest versus maximizing collective success. These researchers found that participants whose teams walked in lockstep were significantly more selfless (and thus more connected) during the subsequent game, whereas participants whose teams walked out of sync played more selfishly.

(Shortform note: In addition to making individuals more selfless, marching in lockstep also increases confidence. In one study, men were asked either to walk alone, at their own pace, or synchronously with a partner. Afterward, the participants were shown a picture of a criminal and asked to assess the criminal’s physical stature. These researchers found that individuals who marched in lockstep **evaluated the criminals as significantly smaller and weaker**, suggesting that marching synchronously had increased their

confidence.)

Of course, Cialdini doesn't recommend asking people to march in lockstep with you to win them over. But he does note that, in the workplace, you can implement unifying activities by designing projects that require collaboration between team members. He explains that because employees feel a sense of ownership over projects they partake in, allowing employees to jointly participate in projects can instill a sense of mutual ownership and connection. Thus, creating collaborative projects could make employees more influenceable, as we're more susceptible to influence from those with whom we feel connected.

(Shortform note: Many companies foster a sense of unity by offering *equity compensation* to their employees, which typically involves [compensating them with shares of company stock](#) in addition to their base salary. According to experts, equity compensation can make employees [feel more connected to their company's mission](#), which fosters a sense of belonging at the company.)

The Enduring Impact of Pre-Suasion

Cialdini acknowledges that, although the pre-suasive techniques he's outlined might lead to short-term behavioral changes, they're often insufficient to effect long-term change. Consequently, in this section, we'll explain how to entrench the changes brought about through pre-suasion by eliciting concrete commitments from your audience.

The Importance of Eliciting Commitment

Cialdini explains that **to generate long-term shifts in behavior, you should elicit a concrete commitment from your audience**. To illustrate the impact of such commitments, Cialdini points to several studies showing that small commitments can cement behavioral changes.

For instance, in one study of medical clinics, experts sought to determine how to increase the percentage of patients who show up for scheduled follow-up appointments. They found that the most successful approach involved asking patients to write down the details of these follow-up appointments *themselves*, rather than having the receptionist do so. Cialdini explains that in so doing, the patients were making a small commitment that made them 18% more likely to attend their follow-up appointments.

(Shortform note: Another medical clinic found an innovative way to minimize no-shows by [placing frequent no-showers on scheduling probation](#). During this probationary period, the patients were still able to schedule appointments, but doctors would only see them during breaks from other patients rather than at fixed times. For example, if the patients on probation scheduled an appointment at 2 p.m. and arrived for their appointment, they would enter a queue behind the other patients scheduled at 2:00 and be seen as soon as the doctors had an opening. The clinic found that this practice reduced no-shows, which suggests that you can also change behavior by *enforcing* commitment via consequences for broken commitments.)

Cialdini relates that in addition to shifting behaviors, commitments can also shift long-term beliefs. For example, in one experiment, researchers exposed participants to a happy story. They then asked one group of participants to *rate* a painting and another group to *observe* the painting. Five days later, only those who'd rated the painting reported preferring it to other paintings, suggesting that the commitment of rating the painting positively made their positive opinion of it more entrenched.

(Shortform note: The 17th-century French philosopher Blaise Pascal recognized long ago that commitments can shape our beliefs. Pascal argued that [religious belief is rational in a practical sense](#) because it has the highest expected utility (in other words, if God does turn out to exist, the cost of *not* believing could be

spending an eternity in Hell instead of Heaven. But if God doesn't exist, the cost of believing isn't anywhere near so high). Pascal recognized that many people feel they *can't* believe in a deity, even if they wanted to. To such individuals, he advised making concrete commitments—such as attending mass, taking communion, and praying—because he recognized that [such commitments can induce changes in belief](#).)

Cialdini suggests that following a successful instance of pre-suasion, you should elicit some form of commitment to maximize the chance of effecting lasting change. For example, local politicians at a rally might elicit verbal commitments from their constituents that they'll vote for them in the next election, unlike the majority of voters who never vote in local elections. Likewise, bosses could ask their employees via email for a commitment to finish a project by a certain deadline. In either case, securing a commitment is the crucial step after you've finished the pre-suasive process.

(Shortform note: One research study found that an especially effective form of commitment is a *public pledge* that declares one's intentions. Among participants who were asked to donate a book to schools in South Africa, those who made a public pledge to donate were [significantly more likely to do so](#) than peers who didn't make a pledge or made one in private.)

Exercise: Consider the Effectiveness of Cialdini's Four Preferences

Cialdini argues that by exploiting four of our ingrained preferences (for consistency, authority, likability, and connectedness), communicators can effectively pre-suade their audience. In this exercise, consider the effectiveness of these four preferences—both as a persuader and as one being persuaded.

Which of Cialdini's four preferences do you believe you're most susceptible to? Why?

In light of your previous answer, describe one situation in which someone appealed to your most susceptible preference to influence you. How effective was it?

As a persuader, which of Cialdini's four preferences do you find most effective in pre-suading your audience? Why?

Describe one recent situation in which you wanted to influence someone's thinking or behavior. How could you have directed their attention toward one of Cialdini's preferences to influence them?